



△ GRACEFUL SWIMMER

A platypus moves easily through water using its heavily webbed front feet, while the hindfeet and tail help it change direction.



△ UNIQUE STINGER

Of all mammals, only male platypuses can deliver a venomous sting. Male echidnas also have horny ankle spurs, but lack functional venom glands.



broad tail acts as rudder when swimming

Common wombat

Vombatus ursinus



Common wombats spend up to two-thirds of their lives underground, in burrows excavated with sturdy front claws. An efficient digestive system allows them to extract the maximum energy from the nutrient-poor grasses that make up the bulk of their diet. Thick fur and a high tolerance for low-oxygen environments help them to survive underground, avoiding predators such as dingoes,

red foxes, and Tasmanian devils. Despite their cuddly appearance, common wombats are solitary and fairly cantankerous, readily defending food sources or burrows; actual fighting, however, is rare.

They emerge mainly at dusk to feed, grazing on short grasses and other plants thanks to a split in their upper lip. Their rootless teeth keep growing throughout their lifetime.

- ↔ 28–47 in (71–119 cm)
- ⚖ 55–88 lb (25–40 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Grass, sedges, roots, tubers
- 🏠



E. Australia, Tasmania



◁ MOTHER AND JOEY

Born the size of a jellybean, common wombat joeys remain with their mothers until they are around 17–20 months old.

Parma wallaby

Macropus parma



small, thin forelimbs

The “parma” in this marsupial’s name comes from an Aboriginal word for the species, rather than the city of Parma, Italy. Once thought to have been hunted to extinction, parma wallabies were rediscovered in New South Wales in 1967.

Mainly nocturnal, wallabies prefer forests with a dense, grassy understory that shields them from predators such as dingoes, red foxes, and some birds of prey. In addition to the grasses and herbs that make up the bulk of its diet, the parma wallaby also eats truffle-like fungi, the spores of which it helps to spread—and fertilize—via its feces.



- ↔ 18–21 in (45–53 cm)
- ⚖ 7–13 lb (3.2–6 kg)
- ⊗ Near threatened
- 🌿 Grass, herbs, leaves, bark
- 🏠



E. Australia

◁ WEIGHED DOWN

A parma wallaby joey leaves the maternal pouch permanently only around the age of seven months.